

Breaking lock-ins with Anthos

We have a chat with Google and their partners to understand their take on Google's latest offering, Anthos.

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Google Anthos opens up new possibilities in the hybrid cloud space given its open nature. We sit down with Nitin Bawankule (Country Director Google Cloud - Google India), Nitin Sawant (Partner, Deloitte), Craig Maynard (Director, Operation Sales, Data Center Technologies, Cisco) and Shantanu Rohatgi (Vice President, Infrastructure Management Services at Wipro Limited) to learn more about Anthos.

Cloud providers are doing their best to provide unified solutions but from a client perspective, external redundancies are always a safe bet. What are your views on undertaking a massive expenditure in having an external redundancy as opposed to having it within the same cloud ecosystem?

Craig Maynard: It's one of the things that I love about the partnership with Google on Anthos. The whole value proposition with Anthos is bringing any public cloud in conjunction with private cloud on premise seamlessly together to enable 'develop anywhere, deploy anywhere.' The whole methodology behind Anthos is more of a unified approach.

There have been incidents in the past wherein a cloud service provider's infrastructure went offline temporarily affecting the businesses of their clients.

Wouldn't it make sense to have an external redundancy for such cases?

Nitin Sawant: We have a business-led approach to cloud. While solving and optimising the processes, we take into consideration their requirements which might include a certain reliability in terms of uptime or any metric which requires a redundancy. Then as part of the solution, we could propose a single-cloud or a multi-cloud strategy. So the business problem defines the strategy for us.

Startups tend to focus and adopt cutting-edge hardware which include the latest AI accelerators brought to the market by the likes of Intel and NVIDIA. So when those startups opt for a cloud service, how quick is Google in incorporating an accelerator that's new, incorporating it into its cloud service and making it available to startups?

Nitin Bawankule: We have multiple programs around this and one of them is the Startup Developer Program. They work with multiple incubators and venture capitalists to understand what's happening and hold startup events in the country regularly. This team identifies the startups which are at the cutting edge of technology, where we think it makes sense for them to build India-specific solutions. We provide them One Google relationships, GCP credits, training sessions, familiarisation sessions and more as part of our standard process. We also identify the startups that stand out among these as part of our Sand Hill program and incubate them. There's no financial assistance in this program but it's more about providing them a single-window Google approach. Right from skilling their teams, to helping them build their applications, optimising their applications, connecting them with our

engineers in Mountain View or Sunnyvale, etc. A lot of these startups use our vision API, speech-to-text API and a lot of them are working on Indian languages, which we're working on too. In such cases we ensure that engineer-to-engineer connect is built to help these startups. We have multiple teams working parallelly with these startups as well as the big VCs in the country such as Accel, Sequoia, etc. Whenever these VCs have their portfolio days, we hold a Google workshop as part of the program so that all the portfolio companies can see what Google can offer and then can network with us as well.

Whenever you have a service that works with everything, there are a lot of compatibility layers and middleware involved and each of them has a performance-hit. So how has Anthos been optimised to work with everyone while minimising the performance hit? Also, would consumers be skeptical about moving to such a service?

Nitin Bawankule: Honestly, these are the early days. Whenever a new product is introduced there may be some glitches. A few customers in the US are in the alpha stage and in India, we should have some customers in the alpha stage in the next few months. Google is known for launching any product, even in alpha only, after testing everything. So I'm sure we're worked everything out but just in case something does crop up then with our engineers should be able to solve it.

Nitin Sawant: If you look at the ilities of what the customer wants, it is a trade-off between interoperability, performance, maintainability, etc. So the question around performance is more about response time and scaling. Anthos excels in the interoperability perspective where you have the choice of not being locked in. The next step is performance which can be architected

Shantanu Rohatgi: Apart from interoperability, I think, it is the openness that Google brings in. We're confident that this technology is the way forward. 

